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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Fee could upend foreign worker program

US policy for H-1B visas expected to disrupt local businesses, universities

By **Kate Armanini**
and **Robert McCoppin**
Chicago Tribune

In a sprawling lab in Evanston, Michaël Elbaz watched a tiny mouse scamper across its cage. The Northwestern University postdoctoral researcher has spent hundreds of hours monitoring the animals — tracing the intricate interplay of neuronal activity and decision-making processes.

“You could spend your whole life trying to understand just one part of this,” he said, gesturing to a diagram of a rodent brain.

The research has consumed nearly five years of Elbaz’s life. But a new federal policy may cut his study short.

The French national came to the U.S. with an exchange visitor visa, which is soon set to expire. To remain in the country, he planned to petition for an H-1B visa, the primary employment pathway for foreign professionals. Then, earlier this month, the Trump administration announced each new application would cost the sponsoring organization \$100,000, rather than the previous fees of roughly \$1,000.

The move has unleashed panic across local business and universities, which rely on the H-1B program to fill thousands of positions. It’s an abrupt overhaul to a 30-year program that has steadily built up the country’s research and technology infrastructure.

“It’s quite stressful, because

I don’t know whether, in three months, I will have to pack my things and go back to Europe,” Elbaz said.

Experts say the fee is too high for most businesses and universities to pay commonly, effectively ending the visa for entry-level positions.

“It could have really catastrophic consequences for potential H-1B visa holders, but also for companies and the U.S. economy as a whole,” said Nicole Hallett, a clinical professor of law at the University of Chicago.

In its order, the White House cited cases of American tech companies laying off thousands of American workers, while

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Michaël Elbaz sits on campus at Northwestern University in Evanston on Thursday. He is a neuroscience postdoctoral researcher from France. His J-1 visa is about to expire, and he was planning to apply for an H-1B visa before the Trump administration’s new rule. **STACEY WESCOTT/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**



BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

SHOW OF FORCE

Residents watch while Gregory Bovino, chief U.S. Border Patrol agent, and other Border Patrol officers finish a march along North Clark Street near the Newberry Library in Chicago’s Gold Coast neighborhood on Sunday as part of an immigration show of force. Dozens of federal immigration agents were seen patrolling downtown, and some were met by protesters. **Story in Chicagoland, Page 3**

Party leaders brace for shutdown

Standoff deepens ahead of meeting with the president

By **Fatima Hussein** and **Mary Clare Jalonick**
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — Top Senate Democrat Chuck Schumer and Republican Majority Leader John Thune are digging in ahead of this week’s deadline to keep the government open, showing little evidence of budging even as both sides have agreed to meet Monday with President Donald Trump at the White House.

Republicans say Democrats need to help them pass a simple extension of government funding by Tuesday night to avoid a shutdown, and they will not agree to negotiate until after it’s approved. Democrats say they want immediate talks on health care, and they are willing to shut down the government if they don’t get concessions.

A shutdown is “totally up to the Democrats,” Thune, R-S.D., said in an interview that aired Sunday on NBC’s “Meet the Press.”

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Teachers’ posts facing backlash

Is it ‘witch hunt’ or ‘accountability’ over Kirk criticism?

By **Jonathan Bullington**
Chicago Tribune

All 11 speakers during the public comment portion of the Sept. 22 school board meeting in Kentland, Indiana, were there to talk about the high school history teacher’s social media post.

After conservative activist Charlie Kirk was assassinated this month, the teacher apparently wrote on social media: “(Expletive) Charlie Kirk and his rhetoric. That being said, we need to work together to do better.”

The post spread quickly through the town of 1,600 people, located southeast of Kankakee near the state line.



Brett Miller speaks in defense of a former Valparaiso High School teacher during the Valparaiso Community Schools board meeting on Wednesday in Indiana. The teacher resigned after making a social media comment after the killing of Charlie Kirk. **KYLE TELECHAN/FOR THE POST-TRIBUNE**

Some speakers at the meeting praised her ability to make a “boring” classroom subject interesting. One noted that the First Amendment applies to teachers the same as anyone else. Another person called the negative reaction “a modern-day witch hunt.”

Others, though, felt she no longer belonged in a classroom.

“My 13-year-old, who is learning more each day about this evil in the world, is forced to ask the question of whether or not a teacher she’s passed in the hall desired the murder of another

human being. That’s extremely sad and I’m heartbroken,” said one parent, who later asked the board:

“Will we simply preach to our children the importance of their words and actions and how they will be held accountable for them, or are we willing to follow through and show them what accountability looks like even when it is difficult?”

A similar debate is being waged in communities across

Turn to Teachers, Page 4

New law could assist state’s public defenders

Illinois office to be created to give support amid justice reforms

By **Jeremy Gorner**
Chicago Tribune

URBANA — Christopher Tichenor sat at a table shuffling papers inside a courtroom in Champaign County.

Over the next 90 minutes, the assistant public defender would handle case after case for defendants being arraigned on an array of charges. A man accused of domestic battery. Another with aggravated driving under the influence. Another with breaking into a car. As the cases were being called, Tichenor greeted the brother of a woman charged with retail theft.

He shook hands with a man whose wrists were shackled, wanted on an out-of-state drug warrant.

Inside the cavernous and mostly empty courtroom, much of the action was on a large-screen television as Tichenor’s clients appeared through a video feed from the Champaign County Jail. Associate Judge Brett Olmstead addressed the defendants one by one, explaining what they’d been charged with and informing them of the potential penalties they faced.

The judge also made clear that they could continue to be represented by Tichenor and the county public defender’s office — an outcome that seemed likely for many and would inevitably add more cases to the thousands

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INSIDE

Bears pull off 25-24 comeback win in Vegas

After the Bears pulled ahead with a late touchdown, Josh Blackwell blocked the Raiders’ field goal kick in the final minute. **Chicago Sports**

